

Mountains split. Boats connect.



Mountains kept towns apart. The sea helped people travel and trade.

- Each city-state had its own government.
- Rocky land made farming hard.
- Boats brought food and goods from other places.

city-state (polis): A city that rules itself and the land around it. civilization: A developed society with its own way of life.

YOUR TURN

Point to the mountains. Why did separate city-states grow?

- A. Mountains made it hard to reach other towns.
- B. Every town shared the same king.

Up for temples. Down for shopping.



Two places. Two jobs. Look UP at the acropolis. Look DOWN at the agora.

- Acropolis: a protected hilltop with temples.
- Agora: a public place to shop, meet and talk.
- Athens' Parthenon was a temple to Athena.

acropolis: The fortified hilltop. Say: uh-KROP-uh-lis. agora: The marketplace and meeting place. Say: AH-guh-ruh.

YOUR TURN

You need a new clay pot. Where would you go?

- A. The acropolis
- B. The agora

Athens or Sparta?



ATHENS: learn and create

SPARTA: train and obey

Athens trained minds. Sparta trained soldiers.

- Athens: learning, art, music and new ideas.
- Sparta: strength, discipline and obeying orders.
- Spartan boys left home for military training at seven.

Women in neither city could vote. Spartan women had more freedom.

YOUR TURN

Which child is more likely to practice public speaking and music?

- A. An Athenian schoolboy
- B. A Spartan boy in military training

Illustration for learning, not an exact historical reconstruction.

Who gets to decide?

Democracy

Citizens decide.



Oligarchy

A small group rules.



Tyranny

One takes power by force.



Democracy: citizens decide. Oligarchy: a few rule. A tyrant takes power by force.

- Athens: eligible male citizens voted directly.
- Sparta: a small group held the main power.
- Not everyone in Athens was allowed to vote.

Citizen = rights and duties. Tyrant = seized power by force; not restricted by law.

YOUR TURN

Could every person living in Athens vote?

- A. Yes, every resident could vote.
- B. No. Only eligible free Athenian male citizens.

Stories gave answers.



Greek myths explained the world and taught lessons.

- Thunder? A myth could connect it to Zeus.
- Stormy seas? A myth could connect them to Poseidon.
- Pandora's story explained troubles and hope.

mythology: A culture's collection of traditional stories.

YOUR TURN

In Pandora's story, what remained after troubles escaped?

- A. A shield
- B. Hope

Pericles helped Athens shine.



Pericles helped Athens shine during its Golden Age.

- He was an Athenian general and political leader.
- He supported citizens taking part in democracy.
- He backed great buildings, including the Parthenon.

Pericles: Say PAIR-uh-kleez. Think: peak Athens.

YOUR TURN

Which city did Pericles lead?

- A. Athens
- B. Sparta

Illustration for learning, not an exact historical reconstruction.

Ten words. Ten picture clues.

Use the click-through guide to flip these cards one at a time.



civilization

A society marked by developed arts, sciences, government, and social structure

Clue: A whole society and its way of life.



city-state (polis)

An independent city that has its own government and controls the surrounding land

Clue: A city that works like a small country.



acropolis

A fortified hilltop in an ancient Greek city, often with temples and public buildings

Clue: UP for temples and protection.



mythology

A collection of traditional stories (myths) belonging to a particular culture, often explaining beliefs about the world, nature, or gods

Clue: Myths have meanings.



agora

The central public space in ancient Greek city-states; a marketplace and meeting place

Clue: GO to the agora to gather and shop.



democracy

A form of government where citizens hold the power, either directly or through elected representatives

Clue: Citizens decide.

Ten words. Ten picture clues.

Use the click-through guide to flip these cards one at a time.



oligarchy

A form of government where power is held by a small group of wealthy or powerful individuals

Clue: Only a few rule.



citizen

A person recognized by the government as having rights and responsibilities

Clue: Rights AND duties.



tyrant

In ancient Greece, a ruler who seized power by force and was not restricted by law; not always bad leaders

Clue: Took power; not always a bad leader.



Pericles

A famous Athenian general and statesman who led Athens during its Golden Age

Clue: Pericles = peak Athens.

MAKE IT A GAME

You explain. Grown-up guesses.

Pick a word. Describe it without saying it.

Example: "I am high above the city. People go to my temples and shelter behind my walls."

Answer: acropolis.

A little each day.

TONIGHT / OCTOBER 7

15 minutes: the six pictures

Ask what she notices. Read the short idea. Let her explain it back. Try each quick check.

TOMORROW / OCTOBER 8

15 minutes, then a break

Use the ten word cards. After a break, try the click-through quiz. Review only the words she misses.

FRIDAY / OCTOBER 9

5 minutes: the tricky bits

Ask: mountains or boats? Athens or Sparta? Acropolis or agora? End with a few tricky words.

Picture answers: 1 A; 2 B; 3 A; 4 B; 5 B; 6 A.

Real quiz: 10 vocabulary questions (75 points) + five main ideas (25 points). Our click-through quiz uses three choices to keep practice simple.

Reading details: The following pages contain the complete detailed notes from the six class readings. The online guide keeps these behind a reveal. Vocabulary definitions match the teacher's slides.

Teacher's directions: Review the Study Site, play Wayground Mastery Mode for vocabulary, reread the Explore texts, and review the Main Ideas Exit Ticket in Canvas. The exit ticket and key could not be verified.

[Open the teacher's study site and original readings](#)

Prepared October 7, 2026 from Kristi Myers' ParentSquare announcement, linked Study Tips, vocabulary slides and six readings. Illustrations and practice activities were created for this guide.

Mountains & boats

Mountains: about 80%

About 80% of Greece is mountainous. Steep, rocky ground made roads difficult to build. Land travel was slow and dangerous.

Why separate city-states?

Mountains acted like walls between communities. Instead of one large country, independent city-states grew. Each polis had its own government, laws and traditions, and controlled the land around it.

Finding food

The soil was thin and rocky, with little flat farmland. Greeks also fished and traded for food. Fish and other seafood were important in their diet.

Peninsula, seas and islands

A peninsula is almost surrounded by water. Greece has the Ionian Sea to the west, the Aegean Sea to the east and the Mediterranean Sea to the south. Thousands of large and small islands lie in these waters.

The sea was a highway

Greeks became skilled sailors and shipbuilders. Sea travel helped them communicate with other city-states, trade for goods they could not grow, and explore new lands.

Mountains & boats (continued)

New settlements

As populations grew and farmland became scarce, Greeks established colonies, meaning new settlements, around the Mediterranean and Black Seas. This spread Greek culture.

High ground for protection

Small city-states could face rival cities or invaders. They often built on high ground that was easier to defend. That fortified hilltop was the acropolis. Its temples and walls are in Picture 2.

Geography shaped their lives

The reading connects mountains, seas and islands to Greek sailors, warriors and independent thinkers. Geography shaped their separate governments and where they built important places.

From the teacher's introduction slide

A civilization has its own language and way of life. The slide gives Ancient Greece, Ancient Rome, the Maya, the Aztec and the Inca as examples. It connects civilization to the Latin word *civis*, meaning someone who lives in a town. The five social-studies strands shown are history, geography, government/civics, economics and culture.

Hilltop & market

Acropolis: safety above the city

An acropolis was usually a natural hill strengthened with walls. During war or an attack, people could retreat there. Its height made it harder for enemies to reach them.

Acropolis: a sacred place

The high place was seen as closer to the gods. Temples honored the city's patron gods and goddesses. In Athens, the Parthenon on the Acropolis honored Athena.

What the buildings showed

The acropolis represented the city-state's power, wealth, strength, faith and pride. Its buildings showed citizens' skill, respect for their gods and ability to defend themselves.

Agora: buying and selling

The agora was the central public space in the lower city. Farmers sold crops, craftspeople sold pottery and tools, and merchants brought goods from other lands.

Agora: people and ideas

Citizens shared news, gossip and ideas. Philosophers taught and debated, politicians gave speeches, and friends met. It was the social center of daily life.

Hilltop & market (continued)

Agora: government and law

In Athens, the Assembly often met nearby. Buildings for justice and official business stood around the agora. Much of democracy's daily work happened there.

Agora: community events

Religious processions and athletic contests happened in or near the agora. It represented community, freedom, trade and citizens taking part in government.

Two parts of one city-state

The acropolis provided sacred space and protection. The agora supported everyday public life. Together they were central to the city-state.

Athens or Sparta?

Athens: ideas and trade

Athens was near the sea and became a strong trading city-state. It valued education, art and new ideas.

Athenian school

Education was mostly for wealthy boys, starting around age seven. They studied reading, writing, math, music, physical training, public speaking and philosophy-the study of wisdom and knowledge-to prepare for citizenship.

Athenian girls and women

Girls usually learned household skills from their mothers. Women generally managed the home and had religious roles. Some went shopping in the agora with a male chaperone. They could not vote or hold public office.

Public life in Athens

Men spent much time in the agora, buying and selling, discussing politics and meeting friends. Eligible citizens debated and voted in the Assembly. Picture 4 explains who qualified.

Sparta: the state came first

Sparta stood in a valley away from the sea. It valued military strength, discipline and loyalty to the state. Art, luxury and individual expression received little attention.

Athens or Sparta? (continued)

Spartan citizens

The reading describes citizens as free men born in Sparta. Their strict lives were devoted to the military. Enslaved helots greatly outnumbered them.

The agoge: away at seven

The agoge (uh-GOH-gee) trained boys to be fearless, obedient soldiers. At seven they left their families for military barracks. They learned reading and writing, but physical and military skills mattered more.

The agoge: hardship

Boys had little food and clothing, even in winter, and slept on hard beds. They were encouraged to steal food to learn cleverness, but were severely punished if caught.

The agoge: strength and obedience

Training included running, wrestling, exercise and combat. Boys learned to endure pain, build strength and stamina, and obey elders and commanders without question.

Loyalty before family

Loyalty to Sparta came even before family. Songs and poems praised Spartan heroes and encouraged bravery.

Athens or Sparta? (continued)

Life after training

Boys completed the agoge around 20. Men continued living and training in barracks and eating simple meals together. They could marry, but still lived with their units. Military service lasted until 60, and they had to be ready for battle.

The phalanx

Spartan soldiers were known for discipline and the phalanx: a fighting formation with soldiers shoulder-to-shoulder and shields interlocked.

Spartan girls

Girls ran, wrestled and threw javelins. The training was not for fighting wars. Spartans believed strong, healthy mothers would have strong, healthy children who could become soldiers.

Spartan women

Women could not vote or serve in government, but had more freedom and rights than Athenian women. With men often in barracks, women managed the home, land and helots. They could own and inherit property in their own names, and were often outspoken and proud of Sparta.

Helots and their work

Helots were enslaved people, often from conquered lands. They were forced to farm and produce food for Sparta. Their work allowed Spartan men to concentrate on military training.

Athens or Sparta? (continued)

Fear of rebellion

Helots greatly outnumbered citizens. Fear of a helot revolt helped keep Sparta under strict military control and constantly ready to fight.

Sparta's agora

Its agora focused more on military drills and official gatherings than debate. Boys and men spent much of life training or serving. This military way of life helped Sparta remain powerful for centuries.

Compare their contributions

Both were powerful Greek city-states. Athens became known for intellectual achievements and democratic ideas; Sparta for military power and discipline.

Who rules?

Direct or representative?

Democracy gives power to citizens. In direct democracy, citizens vote on laws and issues themselves. In representative democracy, they elect people to act for them. The reading compares Athens' direct system with the United States' representative system.

Who counted as an Athenian citizen?

The reading lists free men born in Athens. It also labels this rule as supplemental information: both parents had to belong to the Athenian citizen social class.

Who was excluded?

Women could not vote or hold public office. Enslaved people were treated as property and had no rights. Metics were free residents born elsewhere: they could work and own businesses, but could not become citizens or vote.

The Assembly

All eligible male citizens could meet regularly, often in their thousands, on a hillside near the Acropolis. They debated and voted on laws, decided war or peace, and elected generals and other officials.

Ostracism

The Assembly could vote to ostracize a citizen: banish him for ten years if they thought he was becoming too powerful or dangerous to democracy.

Who rules? (continued)

The Council of 500

Also called the Boule, this group of 500 citizens was chosen by lottery each year. It prepared the Assembly's agenda and handled daily government work. The lottery let many different citizens serve.

Juries

Citizens served on large juries-sometimes hundreds or thousands of people-to decide court cases. This was another way citizens took part directly.

Sparta's rulers

Sparta was an oligarchy. Two kings mainly led the military. A council of 28 men over 60 proposed laws and acted as judges. Five officials called ephors watched over the kings and daily city life. This small group aimed to keep Sparta and its military system strong.

Tyrant: use the vocabulary wording

The vocabulary slides say a tyrant seized power by force and was not restricted by law, and that tyrants were not always bad leaders. The democracy reading uses the stronger wording "absolute authority, often oppressively." Both describe one ruler taking power by force.

Why democracy mattered

Athenian democracy had limits because many people were excluded. Still, it showed that ordinary citizens could govern themselves instead of being ruled only by kings or a small powerful group. Its ideas about participation and laws influenced later governments.

Gods & stories

More than entertainment

Myths were traditional stories, beliefs and legends. Greeks used them to explain nature and mysterious events, teach lessons and explore feelings before science could explain those events.

Mount Olympus

Most of the important gods and goddesses were said to live on Mount Olympus, Greece's highest mountain. They were a powerful family, often called Olympians.

Pandora: the gift

In this myth, early humans lived simply and happily. Zeus ordered Hephaestus to create Pandora, the first woman, who was beautiful and curious. Zeus gave her a box-a jar in some versions-and told her never to open it.

Pandora and Epimetheus

Zeus sent Pandora to marry Epimetheus, a titan described as a giant god who was not wise and forgot advice. His brother Prometheus had warned him not to accept gifts from Zeus, but Epimetheus was charmed by Pandora.

The box opens

Pandora resisted for a while, but curiosity grew. She lifted the lid a little. Sickness, sorrow, poverty, old age, hatred, war and other troubles escaped into the world. She shut the lid, but it was too late.

Gods & stories (continued)

Hope stays

One tiny thing remained: Hope. The story explains suffering while showing that hope helps people endure it.

Nature explained by stories

The reading connects thunder with Zeus, earthquakes with Poseidon, and changing seasons with Demeter and her daughter Persephone.

Lessons and feelings

Myths warned about hubris (too much pride), encouraged hospitality, and showed consequences of disobedience. Pandora's story explores curiosity and hope. The gods' love, jealousy, anger and bravery helped Greeks think about human behavior.

Heroes and warnings

Heroes such as Hercules modeled courage; villains were warnings. These stories still interest people and teach about human nature and the world.

Zeus

King of the gods and most powerful. Ruled the sky with a thunderbolt. Known for his temper and adventures.

Hera

Queen of the gods and Zeus's wife. Goddess of marriage and childbirth. Described as beautiful and often jealous of Zeus's other relationships.

Gods & stories (continued)

Poseidon

Zeus's brother; god of the sea, earthquakes and horses. Sailors prayed for safe travel. His anger could cause terrible storms.

Hades

Another brother of Zeus. A gloomy, powerful ruler of the Underworld, where souls went after death.

Athena

Born from Zeus's head. Goddess of wisdom, war strategy and crafts. Protected heroes and city-states, especially Athens, which was named for her.

Apollo

God of the sun, music, poetry, healing and archery. The reading describes him as handsome and driving a golden chariot across the sky each day.

Artemis

Apollo's twin sister. Goddess of the hunt, moon and wild animals. A skilled archer who loved the wilderness.

Aphrodite

Goddess of love, beauty, pleasure and fertility. Described as very beautiful and born from sea foam.

Gods & stories (continued)

Ares

God of war. Violent and brutal; loved battle's chaos, unlike Athena's wise war strategy.

Hermes

Messenger with winged sandals and hat. Guided souls to the Underworld. God of travel, trade and thieves.

Hephaestus

Blacksmith and skilled craftsman. Forged tools and weapons for the gods in a fiery workshop, often under volcanoes.

Demeter

Goddess of agriculture and harvest. Made the earth fertile and crops grow. Her moods could affect the seasons.

Meet Pericles

Before democracy

Some city-states had tyrants: individuals who took power by force. Athenians gradually moved toward a government in which more citizens had a say.

Solon: around 594 BCE

Poor Athenians could become enslaved because of debt. Solon outlawed debt slavery for Athenian citizens. He also let more people, including those who were not wealthy landowners, take part in government.

Cleisthenes: around 508 BCE

Called the Father of Athenian Democracy, he mixed people from different areas into new groups. This weakened powerful families' control. He strengthened the Assembly, where all citizens could vote.

Pericles: around 461-429 BCE

During Athens' Golden Age, Pericles was an influential general and statesman. Say PAIR-uh-kleez. He was a powerful speaker and supported democracy.

Rich and poor citizens

Pericles believed all citizens, rich or poor, should have opportunities to participate in government.

Meet Pericles (continued)

Buildings and achievements

He used Athens' wealth for major buildings, including the Parthenon on the Acropolis. His leadership helped Athens reach a peak of power and cultural achievement.